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Adrian Cunningham

Adrian Cunningham excels on the tenor sax, clarinet, and flute, and leads the band Professor Cunningham and his Old School. A native Australian, he has become a welcome addition to the jazz scene both here and abroad.

Adrian was interviewed via Zoom on March 31, 2021 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I am in Hamilton College in Clinton, New York, and I'm talking to Adrian Cunningham in Harlem. Welcome.

AC: Good to be here, Monk. Thanks for having me.

MR: You're welcome. And I practiced an introduction, so here we go: Adrian Cunningham, saxophonist, flautist, clarinetist, composer, band leader, writer, humorist, occasional vocalist and world traveler. So did I leave anything out?

AC: That's pretty damn good. That's more thorough than my bio that I write for myself so I'll have to steal that, that's good.

MR: Yeah. Well I wanted to start out, I've been fascinated over the years talking to musicians. Many of them have related stories of things that happened to them when they were young, sometimes really young, or sometimes in their teenage years that helped them — set them on this jazz path. Is there something that you remember in your youth that you might now think of as an aha moment or the like?

AC: Yes. Absolutely. Well let's get deep really quickly then. So my dad, he was a big jazz fan. He loved all jazz but he especially loved the early style. Louis Armstrong, Fats Waller, Mills Brothers. And he had a great 78 collection. He didn't have a huge one, it was maybe 50 or 60, 78s but you know we had a Gramophone player, an electric one, you know a 78 player. My brother and I loved putting those records on and listening to them and my dad, yeah, he was very passionate about music. He loved music and he really loved jazz. And my dad and I, like we were very close. He died when I was 21. But he also loved things like football, Australian football, you know he loved gambling, he loved horse racing. So he was a beautiful guy but there was a lot of things I didn't connect with him because I didn't like football and I wasn't particularly into horse racing you know, they were his big passions. But the one thing I could connect with my father on was jazz. So I think that's probably what led me down that path to kind of follow music because it was my way of connecting with my dad when I was young. And of course I loved it, that helped too, and it kind of went from there you know. The aha moment I think was around, I was about 16, 17 in my last year of high school. We had a

time I'd kind of been playing a little bit of jazz with my buddies from school because my school was small and there wasn't a huge jazz department. I mean I look at the kids today and I think wow, like they're so lucky with all the resources they have. I mean internet aside, you know, all of the mentorship I see here — I didn't have any of that unfortunately. I'd loved to have but I didn't have that opportunity. So me and my buddies got together and we got a band together. And at the school camp it was very classically orientated. So I was in the orchestra playing clarinet, and that was fine. But me and my buddies, we'd get together in the break, you know in the lunch break, and go off and play jazz together. So for the final concert at the end of the school music camp at the end of the week we went on and we played two songs. We played — I think we played "Tin Roof Blues" and I don't know what the other, a couple of Louis Armstrong tunes. And all the classical kids just went nuts, like it was crazy the response you know. And here we are just a couple of kids and teenagers just getting together playing Louis Armstrong. And in my mind I was like — am I allowed to swear on this?

MR: Yes you are.

AC: Okay. I was like "Holy shit, this is amazing." Like people just love this music. This could be something I could do because at the time I hadn't really had a path for myself for what I was going to do after school. But this was an aha moment because like wow, people really respond to this music, like it's powerful. And that was a huge kind of light bulb going on moment for me and it just went from there.

MR: It's interesting that you chose, maybe it's because of your father but the era of jazz, those two tunes that you played, because I think nowadays, or even at that same time in the States if teenagers got together to play a couple of tunes they're more likely to be playing John Coltrane or even more current, Michael Brecker or something. So my question is, what was the attitude or thinking about jazz in Australia at that time? Was there more interest in the classic early jazz?

AC: There are a few camps, especially in Sydney. Sydney and Melbourne are quite different flavors. I think Melbourne is more artistically orientated, cultural, it has more European influences, it's a little hipper dare I say. Sydney is a little more, well there's just less culture in the same way. Like my father who loved football, I always said if I could figure out a way to play the saxophone and kick a football at the same time I'd be a millionaire. So I think it was something that was I was in somewhat of a bubble that there weren't any jazz mentors or people playing jazz around me and I grew up with my father listening to the early stuff so that was the stuff that I connected with. And one of my buddies at school, he was a huge jazz fan too, just — not through parents or influence, he just loved, he loved Bird and Diz you know, he hipped me to some old Dizzy Gillespie

two of us — he was a trombone player — the two of us had a real connection. Then we got other buddies who happened to be playing instruments at the school and kind of dragged them along you know, an electric bass player, we got him playing 1 – 5 – 1. So we kind of worked it out from there and we just got it together. So I think it was just a lack of other influences from the outside, that we just kind of got together with our own thing. And I do remember being about 16 or 17 with that same buddy, the trombone player. He said, "Oh man you've got to check out, you've got to check out bebop, you've got to check out" — he gave me "Kind of Blue." And at the time I was so stubborn I was like ahhh — Miles Davis can't even play the trumpet you know? So what the hell is going on? And of course, you know in the next few years I started to mature. But at the time I was no, the trad is where my heart is. And it still is, but it's just that I've expanded my palette somewhat since then.

MR: I'm so glad you're keeping it alive. You know? I'm trying to picture you and your trombone friend the first time, the first few times you tried to improvise. What was going through your head or what was your resources, or were you just like winging it?

AC: I think it was a bit of all of the above. I think the first — because I was very much self-taught when I first discovered jazz. So I did probably what a lot of kids did, there was one record that I'm very grateful to hear because it's still one of my favorites, it called "Ambassador Satch" and it's the Louis Armstrong All-Stars 1955. It was a live concert they filmed, I think it was in Italy. And it was just an amaz — this was not a 78, this was a 33, this was a full record. And it was just, I loved the energy of the band, it sounded amazing. It was live. You heard the audience. So I remember very clearly coming home from school and I'd only just really started to play the clarinet because — well I started piano when I was 11, saxophone 16, and clarinet about 17. But the clarinet, as soon as I picked up the clarinet I was like this is it, I love this instrument. So I remember coming home from school, putting on that live record and playing along and just, you know, imitating Edmond Hall, trying to get close to how he would play the melody or how he would solo. And so I just kind of closed my eyes and pretended I was in the band and hear the audience. So for me that was a really strong impression. That was the way I started getting into it, just by imitating.

MR: You weren't annoyed by the clarinet like, you know, that quote "octave key" after learning the saxophone?

AC: Awful. It was awful. It was hell. It still is hell, oh my God. Yeah. You know I think like anything if you love the sound of it, if the sound just pulls you in you just work through it and you just get over the frustrations you know, yeah.

MR: I'll never forget Buddy DeFranco called the clarinet the "agony stick."

MR: Well was there a point, actually two points I'm going to ask about, that you thought oh I'd like to do this for a living, and then, but I have to go somewhere else to do this for a living?

AC: So I could see doing this as a living, the light bulb moment that was the end of high school, and so then I went to audition for the conservatory of the music, which was the jazz, THE jazz course in Sydney. And the first year out of school I didn't get in because I didn't really know what I was doing, you know I think I kind of played a blues or something and I didn't pass the audition because it was a very small intake and it was very competitive, and you know there's a lot of great musicians. So I didn't get in the first year. Then I started a psychology degree. On the side I started getting jazz lessons. I studied from a very hip graduate from that school and he kind of got me into a lot more stuff. We started playing Coltrane and Hank Mobley, and you know, getting into transcriptions. So he kind of got me on the right path. And then the next year I got into music school. So that was kind of how I got into the conservatory. My, I suppose the next significant step — coming to New York — that happened in 2008. So I'd been out of college maybe ten years and I had a good career in Australia, did a lot of great commercial work, great jazz work, but it was, as you could probably imagine, a very small market. In the meantime I actually came over to the States a few times to study with Eddie Daniels, because he's a huge influence on me, I mean I love Eddie, he's incredible. But a year before moving here I came to visit New York and I kind of checked it out and checked out all the clubs and got some lessons. And I went home and I was so inspired, it was just like, it just filled me. And then I came to the awful realization that if I don't move over here I'll regret it. So a couple of months after being home I was like okay, I've just got to do this. I don't know what I'm going to do but I've just got to come over. So I started to work on a Visa, that took a few months. And pretty much 12 months after visiting I moved over here for good. So I've been here 12 years now. And that was it. Didn't have a plan.

MR: Did you know other Australian musicians who had done the same think, like Lisa and Nicki Parrott? And did that have advice for you?

AC: I knew of them. I think I met Nicki maybe a year or so after moving here, and we've played together a lot since then at a lot of festivals, and Nicki is one of the coolest. She's great. But there's some musicians in New York, because Nicki doesn't live in New York, she lives in Connecticut so she wasn't really kind of hanging out. But there are a couple of musicians here when I moved here, Jason Campbell, a guitar player. He has subsequently moved back to Australia. Since Covid he kind of moved his family over, but he'd been here maybe 15 years. He was a big support for me coming here. You know

come and hang out with him a lot. Nick Hampton is a saxophone player who's been here for much longer than I have, another kind of good support to lean on. But other than that, no, I kind of just built my way up from the ground, go to jam sessions every night, I used to play in the park three or four days a week with guys that I'd met, and you know just all right, here we go, let's do this.

MR: Yeah. Trying to make the scene I guess.

AC: Yup, make the scene. You know and I was 31 at the time, so I still felt like I'm starting again, this was like rebirth here I am, you know, New York, let's do this. And of course it kicks your ass every day. But the desire and the inspiration of being here just overwhelms everything.

MR: When you were trying to get known in the music scene, did you play gigs that you might not have anticipated playing: weddings and so forth and so on?

AC: Yeah I did. The first couple of years I did some club dates with some kind of party bands and, which for me was fine because as I kind of touched upon earlier I did a lot of commercial work in Australia so I was no stranger to playing in horn sections. Like I used to play in the band for Australian Idol which is our equivalent to American Idol, so I'd done a lot of commercial work. I knew a lot of the pop tunes. So you know that was kind of a side of me that I had good experience of doing. I've kind of shed that since coming to New York because it's really not what I wanted to do. So I used to do all the club dates and things like that. And just a little bit of a tangent what inspired me about New York is that no matter what you're into there's the best here. Because you know I love R&B, I love traditional jazz, I love bebop, I love — you know so I would go to all of these sessions, "Oh man there's an R&B session here at the Village Underground and it's unbelievable." These guys play with Beyoncé, they play with Alicia Keys. So I'd go there on Monday, then I'd go to Small's because you'd have the bebop guys who knew all of the heads and shout choruses of all the Bird tunes, it was like mind boggling. And here, the thing about growing up in Australia, you have to be a jack-of-all-trades to survive. But in New York you can just be one thing and you can be the best at that thing and you can go really deep on one thing because you can make a living doing that. You know it's amazing like that.

MR: Wow that's a strong statement. So what do you want to be the best at?

AC: I'm still figuring that out man. I'm still figuring it out. I guess it's in a way it's a weakness in terms of I guess career or marketing is that there's so many things I love to do. You know right now, well right now, I mean no one's working right now, but I have a kind of New Orleans traditional swing band, Professor Cunningham and his Old School, and that's a lot of fun to do. But then I have more modern projects recently. I recorded

different bag you know. So I love it all. And I'm just trying to figure out how to, you know — an uncle of mine always said, he had a lot of freckles, and he said, "One day my freckles are going to join up and I'm going to have an amazing tan." I think about that with my music. One day I'm going to figure out how to put it all together into one thing you know.

MR: I know exactly what you're saying because I've been listening to this, and a couple of things about it, I think you have a wonderful way of playing in and out of styles. Like you know you sound like those high school experiences, you know you could have been Edmond Hall in another life, and then you could be Michael Brecker and you can do these, you can nail these top tones on the saxophone. And I almost pictured you like going back in time and you could have fit into a rhythm and blues organ trio. So I can recognize that this can be an issue marketing. Like what is it that people are going to want to hire me for?

AC: Right. Right. That's a tough one. Because as an artist you have to, you know, compromising for me, because what I really love is everything. So to compromise that I'd have to give up a chunk of myself. So as an artist if you really embrace who you are then that would be me doing everything. Because I really love it. You know I'm not doing traditional because there's some guys in New York that they play traditional, like all jazz gigs because they need the work and you can hear that they don't really like it. So it's hard. Because if I'm true to myself I love it all just as much. I just don't know how to put it together into one thing. But maybe that's not a bad thing. I don't know. I don't know.

MR: Did you make a decision, I mean forming a band is a whole other issue, being a band leader, now I've got to find work for the band, I've got to coordinate. But you made a decision to form more of a traditional New Orleans based group as opposed to forming a group that might have played hard bop or post-Coltrane type music. Can you tell me about your thinking at the time?

AC: I think you know there probably wasn't much forethought behind it, because I still do concurrent styles, you know like I said, there's the New Orleans band and the modern stuff. But I think looking back retrospectively I think at the time I was doing both. I was playing 55 Bar, you know with my own band doing modern stuff, doing kind of groove orientated stuff, and at the same time I still had the traditional swing stuff. And I don't know, I guess the swing stuff just started to take on a life of its own. It got to the point where that band would get, I would get emails and calls about doing gigs without having to work for it, and I find that doing the 55 Bar gigs, it's a huge hassle. Like you're always paying out of pocket to pay the guys in the band because you never make enough money at the bar. So there's only so many times you can do that without thinking oh God it's

just so much work, you know. And I love doing it but it just didn't happen, for whatever reason it became more work than reward.

MR: I want to follow up on that, just for a moment. I'm not sure that a lot of young musicians realize what you just said. In order to play this certain kind of music you had to pay the band.

AC: I think that's a hard lesson when you're coming up because you don't realize that. I'm sure you'll agree. I think, I don't know the current school climate but certainly when I was coming up and speaking to musicians of my age that you kind of get sold, not overtly, but you kind of get sold at music school about you come through school and you'll be a jazz star. That's kind of the under-riding message. It's not come through jazz school and be a working musician doing wedding gigs, you know? It's come through jazz school, we'll teach you the tools to be the next Joshua Redman, or the next whoever. So I think there's a certain misconception culturally with kids coming through because they have the wrong idea about what they're going to do when they come out. And the reality is yes, you're going to have to do a lot of gigs where you pay out of pocket for your own projects, without a doubt.

MR: Are there other things that you learned, like on the bandstand or from older musicians that you had not learned in music school?

AC: Oh yes. I would say ninety percent of it. Ninety percent of what you learn is on the gig you know. From the obvious things, and this is such a cliché, turning up on time, looking good, answering emails or texts when they come in about gigs and not just leaving — you know, all of those obvious things are something that is kind of misplaced I think with young kids coming up, and I was probably like that too as a youngster, a little bit complacent about calling back or being really professional. And I think that's something that you can only learn doing the gig or losing the gig and asking yourself why didn't I get called again? That's an important lesson. But I think beyond that, and a huge, probably the most important thing about me being in New York is what you learn from the energy of a master when you're next to them onstage. And I think hearing the masters of course is priceless. But being next to — I mean Wycliffe Gordon is one of my biggest influences just in terms of a human being, beyond the music. I've been in his quintet for, what, six or seven years now, and just to be next to that man and to feel his energy and to see how he handles situations dealing with musicians, dealing with the business, dealing with having a bad day and being up on stage. That sort of education is priceless, I don't even know how to put it into words. It's the presence of someone like that.

MR: Thanks for saying that. I have this personal feeling about when people think of jazz musicians often times they think they're playing anything they want. They're playing

might feel crappy, but you're playing for the audience. You can't necessarily afford, I'm not even sure how to put this into words, to play how you're feeling. You've got to play well.

AC: Right. Yeah. Absolutely. It's something I think about a lot, one of my Australian teachers studied with Brecker back in the day. And a great bit of advice he told me was that Brecker said to him, "Well what you have to work on is having your bad day, your worst day, at a certain level you know. Your best day could be up here, but your worst day can't be lower, it has to still be up to a certain level, your worst day." That's what you've got to work on. And I think about that a lot. I think we have to, you know, our standard has to be so good that our worst day is still great. We have to work on playing our best and we have to work on our worst. That's something I think about too. I think that's really important.

MR: Back to this record for a moment, I was glad to see that, of course you were able to play with some really wonderful people here, but also that you had at least half the tunes were your own compositions. And from what I've learned a lot of times producers and so forth say well not too much of your own stuff right away, you need to play — people are going to read, "Oh yeah I like that song, I like that song, I'll buy it." So how did that happen?

AC: Well that album was more the result of the musicians that I was working with. So I think I mean that's going back five, six years now so I can't remember the exact — I think what happened was I played with Jeff and John at the Vail Jazz Festival. I think we did a set together. And I mean I've grown up loving them but you know it was such an amazing experience. So the record that you're showing, the camera is Arbors Records. And Arbors, the album "Jazz Speak," the one we're talking about, that was my second one. So the first one I recorded for them was an album of Neil Hefti tunes. It was a Neil Hefti project. So that was the first thing I did for them. So that was more of an entryway into having a project, having a name that was a little under-represented in terms of, you know, the jazz canon. So that was kind of a foray into it and I think this being the second project I could kind of introduce more of my own tunes and Rachel Domber, who is the head of Arbors, she is really supportive. She has been an amazing patron, not just to me but to music in general. So she's always been like I trust you, do your own thing, make it happen. So I think I wanted this album to be a little bit of a mixture between tunes that people might know, perhaps kind of reinterpreted, and then writing songs that I know would be great for this rhythm section, you know, Jeff, John and Ted Rosenthal. I just wanted to write stuff that I could hear them sounding great on and hopefully they didn't complain too much so I think it was pretty good.

MR: I had a wonderful experience with the CD because I put it on before I read anything.

first song I had this feeling like oh Adrian's paying tribute to people who came before him. And then I looked and it's called "The Source" and I looked at your thing and it was like man, he got me. That was really very, I don't even have a word for it but I enjoyed the way that happened.

AC: Thank you.

MR: Not knowing the title. You know titles can be tricky, right? Like what do I call this?

AC: Yes. Yeah they can. For me to write there has to be some sort of emotional connection. The best stuff that I write is somehow connected and it's always been like that for me, like to an experience or a person, all the writing I've ever done has been about something and makes me feel a certain way. You know I've never — or I've taken a simple melody and then kind of brought that together into something. But you know I've never been someone to sit down and say well this is a nice progression I'm going to do something with that. For me the stuff that I really like from my own stuff started with a feeling or — and for "The Source" it was like I love being in Harlem and I love the R&B scene here, you know with the organ players up at Sherman's on 125th or the Legion Post is one of my favorite places to hang out on 135th. And so I wanted to pay tribute to, you know, well not only the place but the culture, that's why I'm in New York.

MR: Okay. Let's suppose this question I'm going to ask was asked like 14 months ago. What is the work scene like generally in New York now.

AC: You're asking this for 14 months ago?

MR: Yes. Like I'm pretending that the pandemic did not happen.

AC: Well New York City is great. What could possibly ever go wrong? It's going to be like this forever, Monk. Well the New York scene is really vibrant. It's a place that even after 12 years continues to inspire me. There's just so much music here, there's so many opportunities to hear music and to play you know. There's so many jam sessions you can go to up 'til two, three in the morning you know. It just never ceases to be inspiring you know. And it makes me competitive in a good way. It makes me think okay I can't relax because there's so many great players here, like I heard this guy play this tune, I need to learn that better. And there's no other place in the world that I've felt like that, that I really felt like I've got to get my act together because these guys are serious players you know. And that's the great thing about this scene, it's just overwhelming, the amount of great players here. But that's what keeps the level so high.

MR: Okay, so since then, since a year has passed now, have you had to find ways to do other things now that gigs are almost nonexistent?

AC: It's been pretty brutal. I've been actually dividing my time between New York and Spain. So my girlfriend lives in Barcelona. And I met her three years ago because I'd been doing

lot of time in Spain. We had a good following in Spain so I met a lovely girl in Barcelona and we thought where is this going to go. But then we continued to see each other and it developed into something really good so in the last — since last summer I've kind of been dividing my time 50/50 between here and there. Essentially I need my time in America to keep my green card. So my days here, to keep my residency, because there's still very little work, and there's even less in Barcelona actually. But I think, there has been opportunities to do a lot of online stuff, you know, I've been putting together videos for festivals, you know you've probably been involved in some of that yourself, you know where you have to be videos together, online concerts, things like that. So that's at least something. And my New Orleans band, Professor Cunningham, we released an album through Arbors, well it came out last December. It was recorded all in lockdown, from our own private rooms. And we put it all together. That was quite a project, yeah. A lot of work.

MR: And you probably haven't had a chance to actually recreate those tunes in a live setting.

AC: Well we actually livestreamed a CD release last Friday.

MR: Just the other night, right.

AC: Just the other night. The full 7-piece band. It's the first time the band has played live like that since, what February last year. So that was really nice to hear the music, actual, in a room together you know. And it works thank God. But yeah, I mean to play with a full band, we were all just saying to each other my God it's so loud all these musicians together. We'd forgotten how loud it is. It's like holy shit this is like a lot of noise in this room.

MR: Do you ever look out in clubs and, I do this myself if I'm playing in a band and if I look out and if I see people leaning over to each other and yelling at each other that maybe we need to adjust our volume. But that leads me to another sort of inquiry about the role of entertainment in this music, and how it can differ from one setting to another, and are you comfortable with being an entertainer?

AC: Yes and no. I think it's necessary. I certainly feel a great deal of relief often, being a sideman in someone else's band because then I can just be — okay now I can just play I don't have to think about anything else. You know being a band leader is really juggling. You have to do all these things. While you're playing you have to be thinking about the next tune, or you have to be thinking about, you know, okay who are we going to feature, has everyone been featured, you know there's just so many things to put together beyond the entertaining thing. But I think it's really important to connect with your audience and I think it's something that a lot of musicians perhaps don't emphasize enough. Because we tend to idolize the great player, you know like Brecker for example. I mean his

all Brecker. We're not all, you know, but you also, I'm hugely influenced also by the history of music, bands like Dizzy or look at Duke Ellington, and they were entertainers. They brought something beyond the music. Duke Ellington's sets were incredible, and his musicianship, and even the choreography with the horn sections on those early bands. I mean try and get a modern horn section to dance around, they'll murder you. Are you kidding? They'll quit on the spot.

MR: People breaking their embochures, clack the trumpets together. Yeah. You want me to what?

AC: You want me to smile?

MR: Have you got enmeshed in the trad jazz controversy like what does trad jazz actually mean?

AC: No I didn't even realize there was a controversy. Please enlighten me.

MR: Well if you hear about it, you know, if you hear about it don't go there.

AC: Is it the Dixieland reference? That word?

MR: Yes it's partly that, it's partly like what is the Chicago school, the whole thing. It is a little hard to, trad jazz I don't think gets the respect that other forms do for whatever reasons, but I sometimes think it's because it's too upbeat. Like people don't think it's serious because it's so darn happy.

AC: I think trad jazz went in a direction that I think removed some of the foundations of what it was about. I mean Louis Armstrong was such an ambassador for the New Orleans style. And then I think it kind of tends to have lost the — dare I say — the black influence and tended to be just the color of a bunch of white dudes you know, and certainly growing up for me, well I was Australian, not everyone that's white in Australia plays jazz but you know you go to the festivals and there's a lot of corny old guys playing, you know this kind of ricky-ticky stuff without a real connection to what you can hear on the records it kind of became a little less hip dare I say? But I'm not sure how to answer that. I think it's a complicated question, isn't it?

MR: It is. Rossano Sportiello said something once to me that really made an impression on me when he was in his late teens learning to play, much like you were I think in clubs and stuff, and if they had a particularly good night he said that would say to one another, "You were wonderful tonight, you sounded American." And I wonder if in Australia is that a goal or is it not really an issue, to sound American and what would that mean anyway?

AC: That's a whole other topic of discussion that's very complex. I think, because it's tricky isn't it, because fundamentally this is American music and jazz will always be American. I mean it's such a huge cultural gift to the world, this music, but of course jazz at the

with Cuban or whatever. I mean, you know, jazz is something that is welcoming to other styles and it turns into something new but I think it will always be fundamentally American. There are some jazz organizations in Australia, kind of contemporary jazz organizations, and rather than use the word "jazz" they say "improvised music." So they kind of — glibly they're kind of detaching themselves from the tradition of American music. They're saying hey, we're making this our own, so it becomes more improvisation based, more original music based, and certainly a lot of the stuff that people compose in Australia is less swing orientated and more straight-eighth orientated or world music influences is a big movement for that. So there's a movement for contemporary music to be away from jazz in Australia, it's like let's not call this jazz, this is not American music, now it's "improvised music." So you know there's a lot of factors to it. There's the traditionalists that really love the American music and the history of it, and there's cats in Australia that study really all the recordings and they know their business and they play American. I don't know what that means. But I think you know yeah, it's complicated. What do you think?

MR: I'm fascinated by — I second your thoughts about jazz and I think that America's most important export has been its music starting with blues and jazz and rock & roll and hip hop, and the spread of it around the country is amazing. You know you can listen to music from South Korea that sounds like hip hop, it's just that they're singing in Korean. So I guess popular music has been extremely influenced by American music around the world and I guess that's the best I can think. I'm fascinated by some of those stories way back in the late twenties when they were recording and they couldn't record the drums because it made the stylus fall off the wax so they used a woodblock instead and then the French musicians were copying that and so they used a woodblock because that's what they heard. I think that stuff is just so fascinating.

AC: Yeah. There's a touch of folklore to that, isn't there.

MR: Indeed. All right here's a tough one. What makes something swing?

AC: You're the one with all the books in the background, you tell me.

MR: They try but you know I actually like it when certain things are just undefinable because if you can define everything then nothing is magic anymore, that's sort of my attitude about it.

AC: That's true. It's so complex. I really, it's probably a common analogy but likening jazz and improvising to language, you know, and you can tell, having been spending some time in Spain and hearing the Spanish vocalists sing American tunes you know in one bar that they don't speak English well because the way they sing it's like you can tell the vowels are terrible you know. Not terrible but you know what I mean. They're not, you

about imitation, you really have to internalize so much of it. And I think that's certainly one of the reasons why I moved here, because I wanted to speak the language and I knew that if I really wanted to get it I'd have to be immersed in it. You know. And it's something you can't get just listening to records you know I think there's a cultural aspect to it. Jazz makes sense in New York. You know walk down the street, go to the clubs, feel the pulse of Harlem going to bars, and it just makes sense here. In Australia it doesn't make sense, jazz, you know? It's great music and it makes you feel good, but it doesn't fit you know? It fits here. And so I think the cultural aspect is really important. And I don't know how to put it together in terms of a swing feel, but I know it's an important aspect of being able to swing and understanding.

MR: Okay. What kind of music fits in Australia?

AC: That's interesting because Australia, culturally speaking, doesn't really have an identity. And I think it's kind of fascinating. It's something you don't realize until you're out of it, but Australia's music, Australia's cuisine, Australia's culture, it's old, based on something else. So if we just look at Australian music, nothing we have is original, other than Aboriginal music, which is very much — it's beautiful and it's deep and it's tribal but it's got no relevance to modern culture you know, it's very separate. So that's probably the most Australian music we have. But all of the stuff that's come out in the last two hundred years has either been European influenced — all of our famous folk songs have been melodies ripped off from old English songs, so we have no original folk songs — they were like ah you just took this melody and put new words on it. Even "Waltzing Matilda" which is our most famous Australian song, that was a melody based on an old tune too. And all the modern pop and rock, it's all rock, it's all pop, it's all American we've just kind of fit it in. So that makes more sense to Australia. Aussie-rock, we call it, you know, Australian-rock. But there's not really a strong identity of its own and I think it's just too young. We're two hundred years old, we spent the first hundred years, you know, dying of starvation and trying to make our way through a desert, so I think we're really too young to really have any identity of our own.

MR: Wow. And by the way "Waltzing Matilda" is not a waltz.

AC: Um hum. Well the term is actually valtzing, which is a German term meaning to wander.

MR: Oh, thank you.

AC: And Matilda is like the knapsack, because he'd wander around with his knapsack over his back, so that's the matilda. So "Waltzing Matilda" is a guy valtzing through the countryside with his matilda. Why it's a German word I do not know. I can't tell you that. But that's what "Waltzing" means.

MR: I'm so happy to learn that.

MR: If you could get in a time machine and go to a specific, oh I'll say a musical event, a recording event, is there something that you would just really like to be at and witness?

AC: Wow. You know I think being not particularly specific but I'd love to have seen New York in the 70s, I'd love to have been here when there was just so much happening, you know when you had, well I'm a big Brecker fan so you'd hang out at Seventh Avenue South and see Jaco playing and all those geniuses and just seeing that, it just seemed like New York had such an incredible cultural life. It was probably, the city must have been so shitty in the seventies. You must have been — were you old enough to go out in the seventies? No.

MR: Oh yes. But I didn't, not in New York. But yes, New York, from my recollection did have rough years during that decade as far as how the city was doing. But I find it interesting that you say that because maybe older musicians might say yeah I'd love to go to New York but they might have said during the 52nd Street heyday. So I think it's very interesting that you say the seventies.

AC: For some reason that's always appealed to me, it just sounds like such a fun time. 'Cause so many of the musicians that I grew up — well that's the thing, my palate is pretty wide. You know, I think being alive in the fifties and hearing Bird play must have been extraordinary, and being at Minton's. It's funny, you look at those old photos and you see pictures of Bird and he's playing to like five people. There's lots of photos where he's just doing a gig, this is crazy you know.

MR: I know, as many times as you hear the real story it's like naa, I'd rather have my fantasy. Right?

AC: Right. I know, that's it isn't it. We romanticize these legends and rightfully so, because obviously he's a genius and he'd be more so a genius to be playing at that level to five people. If that was me I'd be like I don't give a shit — but here he is doing his genius thing to five people, it doesn't matter. That's extraordinary. But yeah, we tend to romanticize the times you know.

MR: Did you hear in your formative years a particular tenor player that you became enamored of for some time?

AC: I've gone through a lot of phases. I think my first, probably my first was Sonny Rollins. And I think the bridge for me from traditional to bebop or post-trad, I don't know what you want to call the early Sonny stuff, but it was his sense of melody really hit me hard. His — what's the word — just his sense of melody and melodic development. That was a huge influence on me. And also I think, who else, Lester Young was huge. I think at that time those two guys were really big for me, and really important for me. And Stan Getz, once again melodically Stan Getz, I think those three. And then from there I kind of got

sound, it's so complex and it's just so raw. It's extraordinary. I really love — yeah, I think Bob Berg's sound is incredible. And he's someone I would have loved to have heard live.

MR: I'm glad you said that, when you said his sound is so complex. When you're playing, let's say you're playing "Don't Get Around Much Anymore" and then you play a Brecker tune or one of your own tunes that's more contemporary, do you purposely adjust your tenor sound?

AC: I think, you know I think the best way yes, to a point, the best way to kind of think about it is to, this is the way I approach all this music that it's the same language but it's a different accent. So certainly when I'm playing the early stuff, "Don't Get Around Much Anymore" I'm going to be playing much more relaxed embouchure and I'm not going to be playing as hard. But if I'm playing, yeah, a Brecker tune or something that's really high energy I'm going to be putting a lot more air through the horn, I'll be certainly approaching with less vibrato than I would be and a subtone obviously would be, so I think it's still me but I'm kind of adjusting the accent I think, yeah. Unfortunately I'm not blessed with one of those sounds that people hear you and go that's Brecker or that's Berg or that's Stan Getz. I don't have that. Maybe I will, maybe it's just not my path for the saxophone.

MR: Well do you feel of your three wind instruments, does one of them have, how do I phrase this, which is your most personal sound from your own opinion, of your three wind instruments?

AC: Clarinet. Yeah, clarinet without thought. Clarinet is, for me it's just a very strong connection. I think it's something, probably because I fell in love with it so quickly, you know when I was 16, 17, hearing Edmond Hall then Eddie, they were two sounds, two totally different sounds that just completely bowled me over you know and inspired me. And I think, yeah, clarinet just for whatever reason it's my, if I have to choose a favorite kid that would be the one for sure.

MR: Yeah.

AC: Not that I love the saxophone less but there's just something about the clarinet that I pick it up and there it is. You know? Yeah.

MR: There's a little less competition on the clarinet also, which can be a good thing.

AC: True. True. That certainly helped in New York, especially with the trad scene coming into town. It was something that yeah, that somebody gave me some, kind of some instant work with some of the young — there was a big revival of young trad bands here, so like 30-year-olds discovering the early stuff. And that was mind-blowing to me because I wasn't expecting that, to come to New York and to see all these young kids, and really

kind of a branch of work that I wasn't expecting to get. So yeah, it's an advantage, for sure. For sure.

MR: This is sort of a personal question but have you ever been fired from a gig and have you ever had to fire anybody from a gig?

AC: Yes. Can you hold on two seconds, there's someone at the door.
So I've never out and out fired anybody, just not called them back for the gig. I think you know being freelance, we're all freelance musicians, it's kind of easy just to, especially in New York, to say okay that guy or girl wasn't the right fit let's move down the list, let's find someone more appropriate or, for whatever reason they didn't work. So for that reason I've probably been fired without realizing I just haven't been called back you know? But you know you get so busy, you do other gigs, I mean I'll tell you something that happened a few years ago which was extremely embarrassing. I was doing this recording session out in New Jersey. It was for this kind of like a classical contemporary recording that this composer was putting together. And they hired me on bass clarinet. So my bass was kind of pretty bad, I had to take it to the shop. And I kind of looked at the music briefly and I thought oh it'll be fine, it'll be fine. Then I get there and the musicians are like amazing musicians and I was not prepared and I didn't really check out the material, and it was so embarrassing, so embarrassing. So they were kind of saying well we'll add the bass clarinet later we'll do that. But then it got to the point where I just said okay, I just packed up my instrument and I said yeah, I think I'm the wrong guy for this job, I'm really sorry. It was so bad. It was a great lesson for me but it was just like, oh I was so embarrassed. And the worst part was it was a Sunday and God damn Jersey transit didn't have any trains coming back to the City. Uber, that was like 80 bucks. So that's the cherry on the cake.

MR: Wow.

AC: So that was not a good day.

MR: Yeah that helped you to remember that lesson.

AC: Exactly. I won't do that again, yeah, yeah, yeah.

MR: Man, you just gave me a memory because I had a similar thing with the bass clarinet, you know like a summer concert band and I agreed to play bass clarinet and at the rehearsal I couldn't play the part and the guy said, "All right, we just won't play this song."

AC: Oh it's so bad. Yeah, and you just feel everyone around you, you just feel their energy. I'll tell you another funny story, I was playing, I was doing a theater show in Sydney years ago, like I'd kind of sub in on some of these theater gigs. And it was "The Wizard of Oz" you know, which is an amazing score, like it was beautifully written. And it was right at the very most ultimate scene you know, Dorothy's going to come back to —

MR: She's from Kansas.

AC: Come back to Kansas — so you know, and underneath the dialogue [sings] Somewhere over the —" so it was me and a flute. Nothing else. In unison. [sings] Somewhere over the — right? And so it was the key of E flat so I'm playing my F to my high F you know, on the clarinet. And she's doing the same thing on E flat. Unison. And I had, I got some sort of moisture or whatever happened, it wasn't venting properly. And so it was [sings] Some—where. And she was in perfect pitch and I was like a semi-tone under — just this squawking, gargling sound. It was humiliating. Oh my God. And at the end of it, it was like five minutes toward the end of the show, nobody says anything, we all just pack up and I was like oh — and of course then you've got to do it the next day.

MR: Oh right.

AC: Yeah. And it was fine, thank God it never happened again, but it was enough to, you know you never forget those moments, do you?

MR: I can just picture someone, "Honey, how was the theater?" "Well the show was great but there was this really odd sound at the end, I don't know what it was."

AC: Oh man. I would like to think that these things are always exaggerated in your mind and nobody noticed, but I don't think that's true. Oh man.

MR: This has been a fascinating conversation, and I'll just wrap up with a young musician sees you on a gig and comes up after you and, "Mr. Cunningham, I want to do what you do. What should I do?"

AC: Wow. Well I would tell them practice every day. Practice is such an important aspect of it. You have to put the work in, there's no great musicians that didn't put the time in. So it's really important to play every day. If you want to be great, you have to spend the time. That was something Eddie Daniels really worked me up to when I was about 20. He said like, "What are you doing if you're not putting in the work and you don't understand your scales, you don't understand how everything fits together. So you have to know all that stuff. You have to listen so much to the great players. Constantly listening, transcribe, you have to transcribe. And like we were talking about what is swing, the only way you can really get at this is by transcribing and learning the solos, learning those minute inflections that you can't teach someone, you just have to learn by imitation and you know, absorb that way. And yeah, and just keep at it. Keep at it every day I guess.

MR: Do you think it's true that jazz musicians should be so compelled to play that they have no choice?

AC: Wow.

MR: Well it's been said to me by a number of the veterans like if you have something else that you like as much then you better go do that instead.

AC: I think as you get older as a musician and you realize that it is not an easy path. And I certainly look at my friends in Australia that I grew up with that didn't end up being musicians but doing other things, and they've all got really nice houses and they've all got cars and they've all got grown-up jobs, that I think it does, if you choose this path it's not an easy one. It's certainly financially — I mean if you compare the best musician, the best jazz musician to the best brain surgeon, who's earning — are they even in the same ballpark financially? I mean there's no correlation between skill and time invested to financial reward. So that aspect of it is certainly not easy for anybody, even the best musicians you know, financially are not in the same ballpark as other professions. So I can understand giving that advice. But then I look at my life, especially I've had a lot of time to think the last year you know. I look at my life and I think what music has given me, the chance to travel the world and the people I've connected with and the experiences I've had and the joy I get from playing. It's really hard to equate that to anything else. I don't know how any other job could be as amazing, you know I'm sure other careers have extremely fulfilling, you know, aspects of them. When I look at the gifts that I've been given — when I've gone through tough times, especially the last year, and I think about you know do I want to do something else, because I can see how tough it is right now. You know the path that I've chosen is not rewarding me. Then I look back and I think there's been, what I have received has been pretty amazing you know.

MR: All right. Well that sounds like a happy note to end on. And I enjoyed our conversation, thank you for joining me.

AC: Me too. I appreciate that. Thank you so much.

MR: All right. I'm going to pause our recording and then we'll say our official good-byes.

AC: Great.